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WOMEN'S EMPOWERMENT · BOOK 1 · CONCEPT & OUTLINE

Your Insecurity Is Showing

Concept, positioning, voice guide and a detailed chapter-by-chapter outline for the first book in a bold, witty, tough-love self-worth series for women, with Reality Checks, a word plan and the map of how Book 1 and Book 2 fit together.

01 Concept & positioning

02 Voice guide

03 Chapter-by-chapter outline

Prepared for
Mijke

Series
Book 1 of the "Showing" series

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OVERVIEW

About this document

This document is the editorial blueprint for Book 1. It sets out what the book is about, who it is for, how it should sound, and exactly what each chapter will contain, including the end-of-chapter Reality Checks and the word plan for the manuscript. It also defines how Book 1 relates to Book 2, *Your Power Is Showing*, so the two books work as a series without repeating each other.

It is a plan, not the manuscript. Nothing here is final until you have reviewed it. Where your own experience could strengthen a chapter, you will find a short **Your story (optional)** note. These are invitations, not requirements: the book works without them, and nothing personal will be written in your name unless you provide it.

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SECTION 01

Concept and positioning

The central problem

Most women who struggle with insecurity do not experience it as "insecurity". They experience it as being nice, being easy-going, being thorough, being realistic, or just "not that kind of person". Meanwhile insecurity is making a surprising number of their decisions: what they say in a meeting, how long they wait before replying, who they date, what they wear, what they post, what they say yes to, and what they never try.

The usual advice says: *build your confidence first, and the behaviour will follow.* For most readers that order never works, because the feeling of confidence does not arrive on request. So they wait, and the waiting becomes the life.

This book reverses the order. Insecurity is not only a feeling; it is a set of visible, repeatable behaviours. It *shows*: in the over-apology, the screenshot sent to the group chat, the "no worries if not!", the photo untagged, the third rewrite of a two-line message. Behaviours can be spotted, understood and changed, even while the feeling is still there.

The core idea: You don't have to feel confident to stop acting insecure.

The ideal reader

She is roughly 20 to 35. She is capable, often successful by outside standards, and tired of feeling like she is auditioning for her own life. She is online a lot, follows self-improvement and glow-up content, saves motivational quotes, and knows the vocabulary ("boundaries", "people-pleaser", "overthinker"). She has already been told to "just be confident" and to "love herself". What she has not had is someone who names what she actually does, explains why she does it, and gives her something specific to do instead.

She will recognise herself in moments like these:

- She rewrites a two-line message to her manager four times, then adds "Sorry, quick question!" at the start.
- She says "I don't mind, you choose" about dinner, then spends the evening quietly annoyed about the restaurant.
- She screenshots a text from the person she's seeing and sends it to three friends before replying.
- She has been in a "we're just seeing where it goes" arrangement for seven months.
- She checks who has viewed her story and draws conclusions.
- She sees a former classmate's promotion post and feels behind for the rest of the evening.
- She skips the pool party, wears the jacket in the heat, or untags the photo.
- She says yes to the extra project, the favour, the plan she didn't want, then resents everyone involved, including herself.
- She keeps telling herself she'll start on Monday.

The promise and the realistic change

The promise: By the end of the book the reader will know her own "tells", the specific behaviours through which insecurity shows up in her life, and she will have a practical, repeatable way to catch them and trade them for braver, more self-respecting actions.

What the book does not promise: It does not promise she will never feel insecure again, or that her life will change in seven days. Insecurity will still turn up, especially on bad days. The realistic change is this: **she will still feel it, but it will stop getting the final vote.** She will apologise less and mean it more, ask clearer questions, say no without a three-paragraph defence, stop outsourcing her decisions, and start collecting evidence that she can trust herself.

What makes this book different

Most self-esteem books for women fall into one of two groups: gentle and therapeutic, or loud and motivational. This book takes a third route.

1. **It works on behaviour, not mood.** Instead of asking the reader to feel better about herself, it asks her to notice what she *does*, and gives her a smaller, braver thing to do next. Confidence is treated as a result, not a requirement.
2. **One signature tool, used throughout: the Tell Check.** Every chapter applies the same four-step method (Spot, Story, Cost, Trade) to a new area of life. By the end the reader does not need the book to do it. This gives the book a clear, memorable identity and makes it genuinely usable.
3. **Tough love with a way out, every time.** The voice calls out the behaviour, the excuse and the contradiction, but never the woman. Every uncomfortable truth is followed by an explanation and a concrete action.
4. **Built to be done, not only read.** Each chapter ends with a Reality Check: three honest questions and one specific action for the week. The actions vary (counting, scripting, experimenting, deleting, asking, testing predictions) so the book never turns into a stack of journaling prompts.
5. **A complete arc.** The book moves from *catching* insecurity, to *counting what it costs*, to *changing it*, and closes with a personal plan the reader can keep using. It stands on its own; Book 2 builds on it rather than finishing it.

Title and subtitle

Working title: *Your Insecurity Is Showing*

Recommended subtitle: *Stop Shrinking, Stop Auditioning for Approval, and Start Acting Like You Matter*

It keeps the energy of the original draft subtitle but makes the promise more precise: "auditioning for approval" names the behaviour the book targets, and "acting like you matter" matches the behaviour-first approach (acting, not feeling).

Alternatives for consideration:

- *Stop Shrinking, Stop Seeking Approval, and Start Acting Like the Woman You Want to Be* (the original draft; strong, slightly longer)
- *A No-Fluff Reality Check for Women Who Are Done People-Pleasing, Overthinking and Comparing*
- *How to Catch the Habits That Keep You Small, and What to Do Instead*

Concept presentation (for the book's pitch)

Your Insecurity Is Showing is a bold, funny and practical reality check for women who are tired of shrinking. It starts from an uncomfortable truth: insecurity isn't a private feeling, it's a set of habits everyone can see. The over-apologising. The screenshots sent to the group chat. The "I don't mind, you choose". The relationship you're still "seeing where it goes" with. In the voice of a big sister who loves you too much to lie to you, the book names these habits one by one, explains why they made sense once, and shows exactly how to trade each of them for something braver. You won't be asked to feel confident first. You'll be shown how to stop acting insecure now, and let the confidence catch up.

SECTION 02

Voice guide

The voice in one sentence

A big sister who notices everything, says it out loud, makes you laugh about it, and then sits down with you to fix it.

The four qualities requested (direct, challenging, witty, empowering) work as a sequence inside almost every section:

Quality	What it means on the page	What it must not become
Direct	Short sentences. Plain words. Says what it means in the first line, not the third paragraph. Uses "you" and speaks to one reader.	Bossy, preachy, or a list of commands without explanation.
Challenging	Points to the contradiction between what the reader says and what she does. Questions her favourite excuses.	Accusing, shaming, or implying she's weak or lazy.
Witty	Humour comes from precise observation of recognisable behaviour: the details she thought only she did.	Sarcasm aimed at the reader, at other women, or at bodies, mental health or identity.
Empowering	Every call-out is followed by the reason behind the behaviour and a specific, doable alternative. Credits the reader's intelligence.	Empty cheerleading ("You're a queen!") or promises the book can't keep.

The rhythm of a section: Call it, Get it, Change it

To keep the tone consistent across many writing sessions, each main section follows a simple three-beat rhythm:

1. **Call it.** Open with a scene or behaviour the reader recognises, told with humour and precision.
2. **Get it.** Explain *why* she does it, without jargon and without blame. The behaviour usually made sense once; it protected her from something.
3. **Change it.** Give the trade: a script, a rule, an experiment or a small action.

A chapter that only does beat 1 becomes a roast. A chapter that only does beat 2 becomes a lecture. A chapter that only does beat 3 becomes a manual. The book needs all three.

Who the humour is aimed at

Fair targets: behaviours, excuses, contradictions, rituals (the 1 a.m. scroll, the "quick question" that is not quick), cultural scripts that sell women smallness, and the absurd lengths we go to in order to avoid a two-minute awkward conversation.

Never targets: the reader's worth, intelligence, appearance or body; mental health conditions; other women as a group; any identity, background or relationship status; the people she loves.

Guardrails

- **No body shaming**, including "positive" shaming (praising thinness, or framing bodies as projects). The body chapter is about decisions, not appearance.
- **No stereotypes about women.** The book criticises the scripts women have been handed ("be nice", "don't be too much", "other girls are competition"), not women themselves. No "girls are dramatic", "women are catty", and similar shortcuts.
- **No diagnoses.** The book does not label the reader or anyone in her life (no "you have anxious attachment", "he's a narcissist", "that's trauma"). It describes behaviour and effects. Where a topic can involve real clinical difficulty (anxiety, low mood, disordered eating, controlling relationships), the text includes a short, warm note encouraging professional support.
- **Not everything is willpower.** The book acknowledges that upbringing, culture, money, health, time and responsibilities shape what is possible. The message is "you have more choice than your habits suggest", never "if you're struggling, you're not trying hard enough".
- **No invented facts.** No made-up statistics, studies, quotes or credentials. Any factual claim used in the manuscript is either common knowledge or sourced and checked. Hypothetical scenarios are presented as hypothetical ("Picture this..."), never as real case studies.
- **No borrowed voice.** The book takes the general energy of popular tough-love creators (frank, warm, quotable) but uses none of their catchphrases, signature words, persona or branding. Trend vocabulary is used sparingly and only when it is generic.
- **Inclusive by default.** Dating examples use neutral language ("the person you're seeing") wherever natural, so every reader can see herself in them.

Words and habits

Use	Avoid
Concrete verbs: send, ask, delete, say, leave, keep	Vague verbs: embrace, manifest, journey, unlock
"You might", "most of us", "a lot of us"	"All women...", "girls always..."
"Here's what that costs you"	"You should be ashamed"
Specific numbers in exercises: "two sentences", "seven days"	"Just", "simply", "easy" (they make the reader feel worse when it isn't)
Short paragraphs, occasional one-line paragraphs for punch	Long theory sections; clinical or academic language

Voice samples (tone only)

These lines show the intended tone. They are examples for calibration, not extracts from a chapter.

- "Overthinking feels like work. It isn't. It's worrying in a nice outfit."
- "You didn't 'just check' their profile. You ran a full investigation, found nothing, and still felt worse. That's not curiosity. That's a habit asking to be fed."
- "'No worries if not!' There are worries. There are so many worries. You rewrote that sentence four times."
- "If it takes three paragraphs to say no, it isn't a no. It's a negotiation you've opened against yourself."
- "You compared your ordinary Tuesday to her best photo from a holiday eight months ago. Of course you lost. The game was rigged before you unlocked your phone."
- "Your group chat loves you. Your group chat also has eleven opinions, and none of them have to live your life."
- "Nobody becomes confident first and brave second. It goes the other way round, and yes, the first part is uncomfortable."
- "You're allowed to be liked a little less in exchange for being respected a lot more. That's not a loss. That's a very good trade."
- "I'm not telling you this to make you feel bad. You already do that beautifully on your own. I'm telling you because someone should say it out loud and then stay to help."

Calibration: too harsh, too soft, on voice

	Example
Too harsh	"Stop being so needy. Nobody wants to date someone that insecure."
Too soft	"It's totally okay to want reassurance sometimes! Be gentle with yourself."
On voice	"Wanting reassurance is human. Needing it before you can reply to a text is a pattern. And patterns can be changed, starting with this one."

	Example
Too harsh	"You're lazy and you know it."
Too soft	"Rest is productive too! Start whenever you feel ready."
On voice	"You're not lazy. You've been making promises to yourself that were designed to be broken. Let's make one you can actually keep."

Your own voice and stories

The book is written in your first person, so it should sound like you on your best, most honest day. Two things will help keep it authentic:

- **Your own stories.** Each chapter has an optional "Your story" prompt. A short, real moment (even three or four sentences) is worth more than any invented anecdote. If you would rather keep a topic private, the

chapter uses clearly hypothetical scenarios instead.

- **A signature touch.** The research suggested a hint of Dutch-style directness ("we don't sugar-coat here") as a distinctive note. This only works if it feels true to you, so it is listed as a point for your review rather than built into the outline.

SECTION 03

Book structure at a glance

The book follows a three-part progression: **catch** how insecurity works, **count** what it costs in everyday choices, then **change** it with concrete actions. Every chapter contains practical tools; the parts show where the emphasis shifts.

#	Title	Core topic	Part
Intro	Yes, It's Showing (And That's Good News)	The premise, the promise, the Tell Inventory	
1	You're Not Shy, You're Scared of Being Judged	Where insecurity comes from; the labels that disguise it; the Tell Check	**Part One: Catch It**
2	Overthinking Is Not a Personality	Rehearsing, replaying, decoding: the internal engine	Part One
3	Your Group Chat Is Not Your Therapist	Reassurance-seeking and outsourcing decisions	Part One
4	She's Not Your Competition	Comparison, scarcity and envy	Part One
5	Stop Asking for Permission to Exist	People-pleasing and over-apologising in daily life	**Part Two: Count the Cost**
6	Stop Dating Potential	Ambiguity, situationships and over-functioning	Part Two
7	Your Body Is Not the Problem	Appearance anxiety and the postponed life	Part Two
8	Become Unbothered (It's a Skill, Not a Vibe)	Boundaries, guilt and other people's opinions	**Part Three: Change It**
9	Stop Breaking Promises to Yourself	Self-trust through small kept promises	Part Three
10	Main Character Energy Doesn't Need an Audience	Self-approval instead of applause	Part Three
Concl.	Now Something Else Is Showing	Your Tell Map and the bad-day plan	

What changed from the draft outline, and why

- **Overthinking moved from Chapter 7 to Chapter 2.** It is the internal engine behind most of the other behaviours (decoding texts, rehearsing conversations, waiting for certainty), so the reader needs to understand it early. The later chapters then build on it.
- **Validation and comparison stay together in Part One** as the two "outward-facing" mechanisms: asking others to decide for you, and measuring yourself against them.
- **People-pleasing, dating and body image form Part Two**, where the focus is the real, daily cost of the mechanisms. People-pleasing moved from Chapter 2 to Chapter 5 so it can draw on what the reader has learned about fear, overthinking and reassurance.
- **Boundaries (Chapter 8) are now clearly separate from people-pleasing (Chapter 5).** Chapter 5 catches the *reflex* to say yes and apologise; Chapter 8 teaches the *skill* of holding a no when someone pushes back. This avoids two chapters covering the same ground.

- **"Discipline Is the Highest Form of Self-Love" became "Stop Breaking Promises to Yourself".** The original phrase is widely used online and would not feel original. The new focus (self-trust built through small kept promises) is also specific to Book 1, leaving larger-scale discipline and ambition to Book 2.
- **"Main Character Energy, Done Right" became "Main Character Energy Doesn't Need an Audience"**, which states the chapter's argument in the title and keeps "taking up space" for Book 2.
- **A dedicated introduction and conclusion** frame the book with a before-and-after exercise (the Tell Inventory) and close it with a personal plan, so the reader finishes with something complete and usable.

Part openers are short divider pages (part title plus one line) and are not counted in the word plan.

SECTION 04

Detailed outline

The Tell Check: the book's signature tool

Introduced in the introduction, explained fully in Chapter 1 and applied in every chapter:

1. **Spot.** What did I just do? (Name the behaviour precisely: "I apologised for asking a question I'm paid to ask.")
2. **Story.** What was I afraid would happen if I didn't? (The fear underneath: "They'll think I'm incompetent.")
3. **Cost.** What does this habit cost me, each time and over time? (Time, energy, respect, opportunities, honesty.)
4. **Trade.** What is the smallest braver thing I can do instead, next time? (One concrete replacement behaviour.)

Each chapter applies the Tell Check to its own topic, so by the end the reader can run it on any situation the book did not cover.

Format of each chapter

Every chapter follows the same reader-facing pattern:

- An opening scene (recognisable, specific, funny).
- Four or five sections following the Call it / Get it / Change it rhythm.
- At least one practical tool inside the chapter (script, test, rule or worksheet).
- A one-paragraph "The Trade" summary that states the chapter's swap in plain words.
- **Reality Check:** three questions and one action for the week.

INTRODUCTION

Yes, It's Showing (And That's Good News)

Planned length 2,000 words

Objective and function. Hook the reader in the first page, set the contract between author and reader, and introduce the book's central idea: insecurity is visible in behaviour, and what is visible can be changed. This is where the reader decides whether she trusts the voice, so it must be funny, honest and clear about what the book will and won't do.

Belief to challenge. "I'll stop acting insecure once I feel more confident."

Sections

1. **The tells.** A fast, recognisable montage of small moments: rewriting a message six times; opening an email with "Sorry to bother you"; laughing at a joke that wasn't funny; checking who viewed your story; saying "I don't mind" when you do; leaving the group photo before anyone can take it. The point: nobody experiences your insecurity as a feeling. They see it as behaviour. Including you, once you know where to look.
2. **Why "just be confident" never worked.** Most confidence advice asks for the feeling first and the action second. That's why it fails: the feeling doesn't arrive on request. This book reverses the order. Change one behaviour, collect the evidence, and let confidence follow. Also makes clear these habits are learned, often for good reasons, and are not a character flaw or a lack of willpower.
3. **What this book is, and what it isn't.** It is a reality check plus a toolkit. It isn't therapy, a seven-day transformation or a promise that she'll never doubt herself again. A short, warm paragraph, written in the book's voice, explains that persistent anxiety, low mood, disordered eating or an unsafe relationship deserve proper professional support, and that seeking it is a strong move, not a failure.
4. **Meet the Tell Check.** A short preview of the four steps (Spot, Story, Cost, Trade), with a quick everyday example, so the reader knows what she will be practising.
5. **How to use this book.** Three parts (Catch it, Count the cost, Change it); read in order because the tools build on each other; keep a notebook or a notes app; the Reality Checks are where the change happens, so do the action, not just the questions.
6. **Why I wrote this.** A short personal paragraph from you about why this book matters to you. *(See "Your story" below. If you prefer not to share, this becomes a statement of intent rather than a story.)*

Everyday situations to develop. The "sorry, quick question" email; the 2 a.m. replay of something said at dinner; the "I'm fine!" text; ordering the same thing as everyone else; deleting a post after ten minutes because it didn't get enough likes.

Tool: The Tell Inventory. A checklist of about 25 common tells grouped into six areas: *words* (over-apologising, minimisers), *phone* (story-checking, screenshotting), *relationships* (over-explaining, accepting vagueness), *work* (staying quiet, over-preparing), *appearance* (avoiding photos, checking reflections) and *decisions* (polling friends, postponing). The reader ticks what applies and notes her top three. No score, no judgement; it's a baseline she'll return to in the conclusion.

Takeaway. Insecurity is a set of learned behaviours. You can see them, and you can change them while you still feel insecure.

Link to Chapter 1. Before changing anything, she needs to see through the disguises: the flattering names we give our fears so we never have to face them.

Your story (optional). Why you wrote this book; a moment when you noticed one of your own tells. One or two paragraphs are enough.

PART ONE

Catch It

How insecurity really works

CHAPTER 01

You're Not Shy, You're Scared of Being Judged

Planned length 3,000 words

Objective and function. The foundation chapter. It explains where insecurity comes from, what it is trying to do for the reader, and how it hides behind respectable labels. It also teaches the full Tell Check, which every later chapter uses.

Belief to challenge. "That's just who I am." (Shy, chill, low-maintenance, a perfectionist, "just realistic".)

Sections

1. **The flattering labels.** A tour of the identities that often disguise fear, each with what it might be protecting: *shy* (afraid of being judged when speaking), *chill* (afraid of having needs), *low-maintenance* (afraid of being a burden), *a perfectionist* (afraid of being seen trying and not being good enough yet), *just realistic* (afraid of hoping out loud). An important clarification: introversion is real and is about energy, not fear. The test isn't the label; it's whether the label keeps her from something she actually wants.
2. **Where it comes from (without blaming everyone you've ever met).** Insecurity as a learned strategy: the need to belong, feedback from childhood and school, being praised for being "good" and "easy", messages about not being "too much", and a social life measured in visible likes and views. Plain language, no jargon, no blame. The key idea: it made sense once. The question is whether it still serves her.
3. **A bodyguard with bad judgement.** Insecurity is trying to protect her from rejection and embarrassment by keeping her smaller, quieter and more agreeable. The problem: it blocks good things as efficiently as bad ones. It can't tell the difference between a risky situation and an unfamiliar one.
4. **The Tell Check, step by step.** The full method with one worked example presented as a hypothetical: staying silent in a meeting despite having the answer. *Spot* (I didn't speak); *Story* (they'll think it's obvious or wrong); *Cost* (someone else says it and gets the credit; I leave feeling invisible); *Trade* (next meeting, ask one question in the first ten minutes).
5. **Smaller isn't safer.** The invisible losses of avoidance: the application not sent, the idea not shared, the class not taken, the person not approached. These losses are quiet, so they're easy to ignore, and they add up.

Everyday situations to develop. Staying quiet in a meeting; declining a party with "it's not my scene"; "I don't dance"; not sharing creative work "because it's not ready"; saying "I don't care where we eat" and caring a lot.

Tools and exercises.

- *The Label Decoder:* a three-column exercise. Label I use → What it helps me avoid → What it has cost me.
- *The Tell Check* worked example and blank template.

Takeaway. The label isn't the problem; the fear behind it is. Once the fear has a name, it becomes something she can work with.

Link to Chapter 2. The most respectable disguise of all is thinking: "I'm not avoiding it, I'm just thinking it through." Chapter 2 looks at what's really happening in her head.

Your story (optional). A label you once used about yourself that turned out to be covering a fear.

REALITY CHECK

1. Which label do you use most often to explain why you don't do something, and when did you last use it?
2. If that label disappeared tomorrow, what is the first thing you would try?
3. Who taught you that being smaller was safer, and does that lesson still apply to the life you have now?

This week's action: The Label Audit. Every time you hear yourself say "I'm just..." or "I'm not really a ... person", note it in your phone with the situation. At the end of the week, pick one entry and do a 10% braver version of the thing you avoided: say one sentence in the meeting, stay at the party for 30 minutes, show one person the draft.

CHAPTER 02

Overthinking Is Not a Personality

Planned length 2,800 words

Objective and function. Expose overthinking as insecurity's internal engine. It looks like diligence and feels like control, but it often keeps the reader stuck. The chapter gives her ways to tell useful thinking from loops, and tools to move from her head to her hands.

Belief to challenge. "If I think about it long enough, I'll find the right answer and avoid getting it wrong."

Sections

1. **The three loops.** *Rehearsal:* replaying a conversation that hasn't happened yet, in five versions. *Replay:* the post-mortem of something she said at dinner, three days later. *Decoding:* reading meaning into a short reply, a delayed answer, a seen-but-not-answered message, a colleague's tone. Naming which loop she's in is the first step out of it.
2. **Why it feels productive.** Overthinking creates the feeling of doing something. The difference between problem-solving and looping: problem-solving produces a next step; looping produces the same question again in a different font. A simple test: has this thought given me a next action in the last ten minutes?
3. **The certainty trap.** Waiting to be sure before acting. Most daily decisions are "pencil decisions" (easy to change: a haircut, a gym, a weekend plan, a message) and only a few are "pen decisions" (hard to reverse). Overthinkers treat everything as pen. Learning to sort them frees most of her mental energy.
4. **From head to hands.** Practical interruptions: a two-draft limit for messages; a decision deadline with a "good enough" standard; finding the next physical step (open the document, book the slot, send the first line); writing the worry down and giving it a set time later rather than carrying it all day.
5. **When it's more than overthinking.** A brief, warm note: if thoughts are constant, frightening, or affecting sleep, work or eating, that deserves a conversation with a professional, not a productivity hack.

Everyday situations to develop. Rewriting a short email for 25 minutes; replaying a comment made at dinner for three days; watching the "typing…" bubble appear and disappear; researching gyms all weekend instead of going to one; 40 open tabs comparing two nearly identical products.

Tools and exercises.

- *Name the Loop:* rehearsal, replay or decoding.
- *Pencil or Pen?* A quick sorting test for decisions.
- *The Two-Draft Rule:* any non-critical message gets at most two drafts, then it is sent.
- *The decision deadline:* pick a time, define "good enough", decide.

Takeaway. Thoughts are not tasks. A lot of insecurity hides inside the phrase "I'm still deciding".

Link to Chapter 3. When she can't settle the loop alone, she often hands it to someone else. Next stop: the group chat.

Your story (optional). A decision you overthought for far longer than it deserved, and what finally moved you.

REALITY CHECK

1. Which loop do you fall into most often: rehearsing, replaying or decoding?
2. What decision have you been "thinking about" for more than a month, and is it really a pen decision or a pencil one?
3. What would you do today if you were allowed to be only 80% sure?

This week's action: Three Deadlines. Choose three small decisions you've been putting off. For each one, write a deadline (a day and a time this week) and one sentence defining "good enough". Decide by the deadline, act on it, and note afterwards whether the extra thinking would have changed anything.

CHAPTER 03

Your Group Chat Is Not Your Therapist

Planned length 2,700 words

Objective and function. Address reassurance-seeking and the habit of outsourcing decisions. The chapter shows why asking everyone feels calming in the moment but erodes self-trust over time, and teaches the reader to consult other people without handing them the verdict.

Belief to challenge. "Asking everyone what they think is just being thoughtful."

Sections

1. **The screenshot economy.** Screenshotting messages for group analysis; asking three friends the same question until one gives the answer she hoped for; sending outfit photos for approval; polling her followers on a haircut; asking her partner "Are you annoyed with me?" for the third time today.
2. **Advice or reassurance?** A simple test. Advice gives her information she doesn't have and can change the decision. Reassurance gives her nothing new; it only changes her mood, briefly. If she already knows the facts, she's asking for permission, not perspective.
3. **Why reassurance never sticks.** Each time she outsources a decision, she teaches herself that her own judgement isn't enough, so next time she needs even more reassurance. Friends also bring their own fears, preferences and history, and none of them live with her consequences.
4. **Consult, don't outsource.** How to ask well: decide what she thinks first; choose one person who actually has relevant knowledge; ask a specific question ("What am I missing?" rather than "What should I do?"). Building a personal "advisory board": who is genuinely qualified to advise on work, money, relationships, health.
5. **Sitting with not knowing.** Tolerating uncertainty for a set time before asking anyone. A self-reassurance script: what would I tell a friend in this situation, and what evidence do I actually have? And the title's real point: friends are wonderful, but if she needs a therapist, an actual therapist is a strong choice, not a dramatic one.

Everyday situations to develop. The screenshot of a "hey stranger" message sent to the group before replying; asking family and four friends whether to leave a job; outfit photos before a date; repeatedly asking a partner whether everything is okay; changing a decision after the fifth opinion.

Tools and exercises.

- *The Advice or Reassurance test* (two questions to ask before asking anyone).
- *Ask Yourself First:* write your own answer before sending the question.
- *My Advisory Board:* a short map of whose input is worth seeking, on which topics.

Takeaway. Other people's opinions are input, not a verdict. Her own judgement improves only when she uses it.

Link to Chapter 4. Constantly checking how others see her leads straight into the next habit: measuring herself against them.

Your story (optional). A time you went against the group's advice and were right, or followed it and regretted it.

REALITY CHECK

1. In the last week, how many times did you ask someone's opinion on something you had already decided?
2. Whose opinion do you seek most often, and is that person actually qualified on the topics you ask them about?
3. What would you decide about your current dilemma if no one were ever going to know?

This week's action: The 24-Hour Rule. For seven days, before asking anyone for an opinion, write down your own answer in your notes app and wait 24 hours. Keep a tally: how many times you wanted to ask, how many times you still asked after 24 hours, and how many times the answer you received changed your decision.

CHAPTER 04

She's Not Your Competition

Planned length 2,800 words

Objective and function. Unpack comparison as the measuring habit of insecurity: how it works, why it hits harder online, and why the idea that other women are competition is a script worth rejecting. The chapter turns envy from a source of shame into useful information.

Belief to challenge. "If she's winning, I'm losing." / "There's only room for one of us."

Sections

1. **The scoreboard in your head.** Comparing is automatic; what she compares, and with whom, is not. The unfair comparisons: her ordinary day against someone's highlight; her first year against someone's tenth; her whole life against one area of someone else's.
2. **The scarcity script.** Women are often taught, subtly or not, that attention, success and love are limited and other women are rivals for them. The "not like other girls" idea is part of the same script. The chapter criticises the script, not the women caught in it.
3. **Your feed is not neutral.** Social platforms show peaks, not averages, and reward content that holds attention. She can't control the algorithm, but she can control her inputs. (General, well-known observations only; no invented figures.)
4. **Envy is information.** Envy usually points at something specific she wants: freedom, recognition, courage, a skill. A method for decoding it: what exactly do I want here, why, and what's the smallest step towards it? Some envy turns out to be noise: she doesn't actually want the thing, only the approval it seems to bring.
5. **From rival to reference.** Practical ways out: genuine congratulations; asking someone how she did it; collaboration instead of quiet rivalry. Also, permission to mute: protecting her attention isn't pettiness. And an honest moment about the uncomfortable relief when someone else struggles: normal, human, and a sign of scarcity thinking, not of being a bad person.

Everyday situations to develop. A former classmate's engagement or promotion post; a colleague's success in a meeting; a friend's visible "glow-up"; scrolling at 1 a.m. and feeling behind; comparing salaries, homes or travel; feeling quietly pleased when someone's launch flops.

Tools and exercises.

- *The Envy Decoder:* What exactly? Why? Smallest step?
- *The Feed Audit:* which accounts leave you energised, which leave you smaller.
- *Compliment the competition:* one sincere, specific compliment to someone you've felt competitive with.

Takeaway. Comparison measures; it doesn't inform, unless she decodes it. Another woman's success is not a statement about her.

Link to Chapter 5 (and to Part Two). Part One has mapped the four mechanisms: the hidden fear, the overthinking, the reassurance loop and the comparison. Part Two looks at what they cost in real life, starting with the most expensive habit of all: making herself smaller to keep everyone else comfortable.

Your story (optional). A woman you once saw as competition and how you see her now; or a moment when envy pointed you towards something you actually wanted.

REALITY CHECK

1. Who do you compare yourself to most often, and in which area of life?
2. When you feel envy, what exactly do you want: the thing itself, or the approval you imagine it brings?
3. What would change if you treated the woman you envy as someone to learn from instead of someone to beat?

This week's action: The Comparison Trigger Map. For three days, every time comparison stings, note the time, the app or place, and who or what triggered it. On day four, look for the pattern, then mute (not necessarily unfollow) at least five accounts that reliably leave you feeling smaller. Finally, take one envy from your list, decode it, and do the smallest step towards what it pointed at.

PART TWO

Count The Cost

Where insecurity makes your everyday choices

CHAPTER 05

Stop Asking for Permission to Exist

Planned length 3,000 words

Objective and function. Show how people-pleasing and over-apologising work in language, at work, with friends and with family, and what they really cost. This chapter catches the *reflex*; holding a boundary under pressure is taught in Chapter 8.

Belief to challenge. "If I'm easy and agreeable, people will like me and I'll be safe."

Sections

1. **"Sorry, quick question."** Permission language: apologising for existing in a space, minimisers ("just", "only", "if that's okay", "a tiny thing"), self-deprecating openers ("this might be stupid, but..."). The point isn't to police words for their own sake, but to notice when language shrinks the message before anyone else has a chance to.
2. **The yes reflex.** Saying yes before she has even checked whether she wants to: covering shifts, volunteering for tasks nobody wants, always being the one who drives, hosts or remembers. The difference between generosity and people-pleasing: generosity is freely chosen; people-pleasing is fear-driven. Test: would I still do this if nobody noticed or thanked me?
3. **The hidden invoice.** What people-pleasing costs: resentment, exhaustion, relationships where nobody knows what she really thinks, and a "yes" that loses its value because it is automatic. At work: taking on invisible tasks, not raising problems, accepting the first offer. (Touched on briefly here; negotiation and career ambition are developed in Book 2.)
4. **The family edition.** Old roles (the easy one, the peacemaker, the responsible one) and why they're the hardest to change. Small, realistic first steps rather than dramatic confrontations at the dinner table.
5. **First interruptions.** The delayed yes ("Let me check and get back to you"); swapping apologies for thanks ("Thanks for waiting" instead of "Sorry I'm late"); deleting minimisers before hitting send; letting a pause sit without filling it with an apology.

Everyday situations to develop. Apologising to someone who bumped into her; telling a friend who is always late "No worries!" for the fourth time; accepting the extra project on a full week; agreeing to the restaurant she dislikes; paying more than her share to avoid awkwardness; softening a valid point in a meeting until it disappears.

Tools and exercises.

- *The Sorry Swap:* a list of common apologies and their stronger replacements.
- *The Delayed Yes script* for work, friends and family.

- *Generosity or Pleasing?* A three-question test.
- *The Minimiser Edit:* re-read sent emails and remove every "just", "sorry" and "if that's okay" that doesn't belong.

Takeaway. Agreeable to everyone, known by no one. A yes only means something when no is also possible.

Link to Chapter 6. Nowhere does asking for permission cost more than in dating, where the fear of being "too much" leads to accepting far too little.

Your story (optional). A yes you gave when you meant no, and what it cost you.

REALITY CHECK

1. How many times did you apologise yesterday for something that wasn't your fault or wasn't a problem?
2. Which yes in your current week did you give out of fear rather than choice?
3. Who in your life has never heard what you really think, and what are you afraid would happen if they did?

This week's action: Count, Then Swap. For two days, simply count every "sorry" you say or write (a tally in your phone is enough). For the rest of the week, replace each unnecessary apology with a thank-you or a plain statement, and answer every new request with "Let me check and get back to you" before deciding.

CHAPTER 06

Stop Dating Potential

Planned length 3,000 words

Objective and function. Show how insecurity shapes romantic choices: tolerating ambiguity, staying in situationships, over-functioning and choosing hope over evidence. Book 1 focuses on *stopping* these patterns: asking the clear question and leaving what doesn't meet her. Defining long-term standards and choosing partners intentionally are developed in Book 2.

Belief to challenge. "If I ask for what I want, I'll scare them away." / "If I'm patient enough, they'll become who they could be."

Sections

1. **In love with a trailer.** Dating potential means falling for who someone could be rather than who they repeatedly show themselves to be. The evidence rule: judge by consistent actions over time, not by words, chemistry or the one great weekend.
2. **The situationship tax.** What ambiguity really costs: hours spent decoding (a callback to Chapter 2), plans kept open "just in case", anxiety, postponed life. Why she accepts it: the fear of seeming needy, and "chill" doing its old job (a callback to Chapter 1).
3. **Over-functioning.** Doing all the planning, initiating, adjusting and understanding; shrinking her own needs to be easy to date; defending the other person to her friends.
4. **The clear question.** How to ask "What are we doing?" without apologising, hinting or making a speech. Short scripts for different stages. How to treat the answer as information, including the important principle that a vague answer *is* an answer.
5. **Leaving without the closing speech.** Ending things cleanly without needing perfect closure or their agreement; handling the urge to check their profile afterwards; why "we can still be friends" is not an obligation.

A short, serious note within the chapter: controlling, frightening or abusive behaviour is not "potential" to wait out, and the chapter encourages contacting a trusted person or a local support service.

For readers who are not dating, each tool is also framed for one-sided friendships, where the same pattern of accepting crumbs often appears.

Everyday situations to develop. Replying instantly to someone who takes three days; the late-night "you up?" message; having met their friends but still not being "official" after eight months; cancelling plans with friends in case they text; explaining their behaviour to friends who are worried.

Tools and exercises.

- *The Actions Ledger:* list what they *said* and what they *did* over the last 30 days, side by side.
- *Clear Question scripts* for early dating, months in, and long-term ambiguity.
- *My Ambiguity Limit:* decide in advance how long "seeing where it goes" can last.
- *The no-checking rule* for after it ends.

Takeaway. Wanting clarity is not needy; it's self-respect. You can't negotiate someone into wanting you, but you can stop negotiating against yourself.

Link to Chapter 7. The fear of being "too much" or "not enough" has another favourite place to live: the mirror.

Your story (optional). A time you stayed somewhere too long hoping for potential, or the moment you finally asked the clear question. Only if you are comfortable sharing it; this chapter also works fully with hypothetical scenarios.

REALITY CHECK

1. In your current or most recent relationship, what has the other person consistently *done*, as opposed to said?
2. What question have you been avoiding because you're afraid of the answer?
3. What would you tell a friend who described your situation to you, word for word?

This week's action: Send the Clear Message. If you're in an ambiguous situation, use one of the chapter's scripts to ask your clear question this week, in two sentences or fewer, with no apology. If you're not dating, choose a one-sided friendship and either say what you need or stop being the only one who initiates for two weeks. Either way, write down the answer you get and treat it as information, not as a verdict on your worth.

CHAPTER 07

Your Body Is Not the Problem

Planned length 2,700 words

Objective and function. Address appearance anxiety by focusing on what it does to the reader's choices: avoiding, checking, hiding and postponing. This is not a fitness chapter, a beauty chapter or a lecture about loving every inch of yourself. It's about taking decisions back from the mirror.

Belief to challenge. "I'll start living (dating, swimming, posting, going out) when I look different."

Sections

1. **The waiting room.** The postponed life: the holiday swim, the photos, the dress, the dating profile, the gym class she'll join "once she's in better shape". Naming everything currently on hold.
2. **Checking and fixing.** Mirror checks, front-camera checks, taking forty photos to post one, deleting tagged images, asking "Do I look okay?" (a callback to reassurance in Chapter 3). Why constant checking tends to increase anxiety rather than calm it.
3. **Neutral is enough.** She doesn't have to love her body to stop letting it make her decisions. A neutral stance: focusing on what her body lets her do and experience, rather than how it is rated. Loving her reflection is optional; living her life isn't.
4. **Other people's mouths, and your own.** Handling comments from family and friends with short, calm responses; stepping out of body talk ("I'm so huge in this", "I need to earn dinner"); accepting a compliment with "Thank you" and nothing else.
5. **When to get support.** A clear, caring note: if thoughts about food, exercise or appearance take up a large part of the day or feel out of control, that's a reason to talk to a doctor or specialist. No labels, no diagnoses, just a door held open.

Everyday situations to develop. Untagging photos from a friend's birthday; skipping a pool party; wearing a jacket in 30°C heat; sitting on the beach without swimming; checking her reflection in every shop window; answering "You look lovely" with "Ugh, no, I look exhausted".

Tools and exercises.

- *The Waiting Room List:* everything she has put on hold until she looks different.
- *The Check Count:* noticing how often she checks her appearance in a day, then reducing it on purpose.
- *Body Talk Swaps:* what to say instead when the conversation turns to bodies.
- *The Compliment Rule:* "Thank you." Full stop.

Takeaway. Her life isn't on hold pending approval of her appearance. She can feel unsure about her body and still go to the party.

Link to Chapter 8 (and to Part Three). Part Two has shown the cost. Part Three is about making the trades stick, starting with the skill that protects every other change: holding her ground when someone isn't pleased.

Your story (optional). Something you once avoided because of how you felt about your appearance, and what changed. Please share only what you are comfortable with; the chapter is complete without it.

REALITY CHECK

1. What have you postponed in the last year until you "look better", and who decided that was the rule?
2. How many times a day do you check your appearance, and how do you usually feel afterwards: calmer or worse?
3. What would you do this month if your appearance were simply not a factor in the decision?

This week's action: One Thing Off the List. Write your Waiting Room List. This week, choose one item and do it as you are: go to the event, stay in the photo, wear the thing, book the class. Before you go, allow yourself one mirror check, then put your phone camera away. Afterwards, write one sentence about what you remember from the experience, not how you looked.

PART THREE

Change It

Trading insecurity for self-respect

CHAPTER 08

Become Unbothered (It's a Skill, Not a Vibe)

Planned length 3,000 words

Objective and function. Turn awareness into a working skill: setting boundaries, holding them when someone pushes back, surviving guilt and deciding whose opinion actually counts. Chapter 5 caught the reflex to please; this chapter teaches what to do when the "no" makes someone unhappy.

Belief to challenge. "If someone is upset with me, I must have done something wrong." / "Unbothered people just don't care."

Sections

1. **Unbothered isn't cold.** What being unbothered really means: caring about people without needing their approval for every choice. It isn't ghosting, cutting everyone off or performing indifference online.
2. **What a boundary actually is.** A boundary describes what *she* will do, not what she demands from others. The difference between a request ("Could you call before coming over?"), a boundary ("If you drop by without calling, I won't be able to open the door") and an ultimatum. Simple examples for each.
3. **Short, clear, kind.** A bank of scripts for common situations: the friend who always cancels at the last minute; the colleague messaging at 10 p.m.; the relative commenting on her life choices; the ex who keeps checking in; being asked to lend money. The rule: no essay, one reason at most, sometimes none.
4. **The guilt hangover.** Guilt is a feeling, not proof of wrongdoing; when she breaks an old pattern, guilt is often a sign of change. Handling pushback: repeating the same calm sentence; acknowledging the other person's feelings without reopening the decision ("I understand you're disappointed, and my answer is still no"). The prediction log: what she feared would happen versus what actually did.
5. **Whose vote counts.** Not every opinion deserves equal weight. A practical way to decide: people who know her well and whose judgement she respects get a hearing; strangers, comment sections and people who benefit from her saying yes don't get a vote.
6. **Kept, not announced.** A boundary that's stated but not kept teaches people to ignore it. Following through calmly and consistently does more than a dramatic speech.

Everyday situations to develop. See the scripts above, plus: the group trip she can't afford; the friend who only calls to vent; the manager who adds "small" tasks every Friday afternoon.

Tools and exercises.

- *The Boundary Formula:* "When ___ happens, I will ___."
- *The Script Bank* for six common situations.

- *The Prediction Log:* feared outcome, actual outcome.
- *Whose Vote Counts:* a simple circle diagram of whose opinion matters, on what.

Takeaway. Disappointing someone is survivable, and sometimes it's the most respectful thing she can do, for both of them.

Link to Chapter 9. Boundaries with others depend on something more basic: trusting that she'll follow through. And most of us break our promises to ourselves first.

Your story (optional). A boundary you held that felt terrible at the time and right afterwards.

REALITY CHECK

1. Where in your life do you most often say yes and then feel resentful?
2. Whose disappointment are you most afraid of, and what do you imagine would actually happen?
3. Which opinions about your life have you been treating as votes when they're really just comments?

This week's action: One Clean No. Say no to one request this week in two sentences or fewer, without inventing an excuse. Before you say it, write down what you expect to happen. Afterwards, wait at least 20 minutes before sending any follow-up, apology or explanation (ideally, send none). Then write down what actually happened and compare it with your prediction.

CHAPTER 09

Stop Breaking Promises to Yourself

Planned length 2,800 words

Objective and function. Rebuild self-trust through small promises that are actually kept. This chapter is the engine of lasting change: confidence grows from evidence, and evidence comes from follow-through. It's not about hustle or perfect routines; large-scale discipline for big goals and ambition belongs to Book 2.

Belief to challenge. "I'm just not a disciplined person." / "I'll start on Monday, when I feel motivated."

Sections

1. **You keep your promises, just not to you.** She would never cancel on her best friend four times in a week, but she does it to herself daily, then wonders why she doesn't trust her own word. Self-trust works like any relationship: it's built on reliability.
2. **Confidence is a receipt.** Confidence comes from proof: from a growing record of times she said she would do something and did it. That is why positive statements without evidence often feel hollow. Evidence first, belief second.
3. **Embarrassingly small.** How to design promises that are too small to fail: specific, scheduled and visible. The all-or-nothing trap. The Monday myth: the perfect fresh start that keeps moving.
4. **When you break one.** No self-punishment, no starting over from zero. The rule: shrink it, don't drop it. The difference between a lapse (missing once) and a quit (deciding it's pointless). How to talk to herself after a slip, the way she'd talk to a friend.
5. **Real life counts.** Willpower isn't the whole story. Energy, health, money, time, work schedules and caring responsibilities all shape what is realistic. Good promises fit the life she actually has, not the life of an imaginary woman with no responsibilities.

Everyday situations to develop. The snoozed alarm; the journal abandoned on day three; the unused gym membership; "I'll reply to that tomorrow"; restarting the same plan every Monday; promising to leave work on time and never doing it.

Tools and exercises.

- *Design a Tiny Promise:* specific, small, scheduled, visible.
- *The Kept-Promise Tally:* a simple daily mark, no app required.
- *Shrink, Don't Quit:* what to do the day after a missed promise.
- *The Friend Test* for self-talk after a slip.

Takeaway. Self-trust is built in small, kept promises. It is the foundation every other change in this book rests on.

Link to Chapter 10. Once she can trust herself, she can start approving of herself, without waiting for an audience to do it for her.

Your story (optional). A small promise you kept that made a bigger difference than you expected.

REALITY CHECK

1. Which promise to yourself have you broken most often, and how big was it really?
2. How do you speak to yourself after a slip, and would you speak to a friend that way?
3. What one tiny promise, kept for a month, would make you trust yourself more?

This week's action: The Seven-Day Tiny Promise. Choose one promise so small it's almost embarrassing (for example: two minutes of stretching after you brush your teeth, or leaving your desk at the time you said). Write it down with a specific time and place. Mark every day you keep it. If you miss a day, make the promise even smaller the next day rather than abandoning it. At the end of the week, count your marks: that's your evidence.

CHAPTER 10

Main Character Energy Doesn't Need an Audience

Planned length 2,600 words

Objective and function. Close the main journey by moving the reader from needing outside approval to giving it to herself. This chapter brings together the earlier tools and replaces the *performance* of confidence with the *practice* of it.

Belief to challenge. "It only counts if someone sees it." / "Confidence means looking confident."

Sections

1. **Performing versus practising.** Performed confidence is about how it looks: the perfect post, the poised photo, the "I'm thriving" caption. Practised confidence is quieter: doing what she said she'd do, speaking honestly, trying things badly. One needs an audience; the other just needs her.
2. **The applause habit.** Posting a win immediately and checking reactions every few minutes; reading every review; waiting for someone else to say it's good before she's allowed to believe it. What she is really asking for when she does this, and why the answer never feels like enough.
3. **Your own review comes first.** Assessing her own work and effort before asking anyone else; keeping a private record of what she has done; celebrating without posting. External feedback becomes useful information rather than a verdict.
4. **Some people won't like this version.** When she stops shrinking, a few people will be less comfortable. That's information about the old arrangement, not proof she's done something wrong.
5. **Main character, not the only character.** Self-approval is not self-absorption. The most secure women can celebrate others (a callback to Chapter 4), listen without competing and take up space without taking it from someone else.

Everyday situations to develop. The gym selfie checked every five minutes; rereading one critical comment and ignoring forty kind ones; eating dinner alone at a restaurant; doing a hobby badly, for fun; finishing a project and telling nobody for a week.

Tools and exercises.

- *The Unposted Win.*
- *Self-Review First:* three questions to answer before asking for feedback.
- *The Done List:* a private record of what she has actually done, not just what she plans to do.
- *A solo outing:* one activity alone, for herself, unposted.

Takeaway. Approval she gives herself is the only kind she can carry everywhere. Everything else is a nice bonus.

Link to the conclusion. She now has the tools. The conclusion turns them into a personal plan she can keep using long after the last page.

Your story (optional). Something you are proud of that you never posted, or a moment you realised you no longer needed someone's approval.

REALITY CHECK

1. What was the last thing you did mainly so that someone would see it?
2. If no one could ever see, like or comment on your life again, what would you keep doing and what would you stop?
3. Whose approval are you still waiting for, and what would you do if it never came?

This week's action: The Unposted Win. Do one thing this week that you're proud of: finish something, try something new, go somewhere alone. Tell no one and post nothing about it for seven days. Each time you feel the urge to share it, note what you were hoping to hear. At the end of the week, write yourself the review you were waiting for someone else to give.

CONCLUSION

Now Something Else Is Showing

Planned length 2,000 words

Objective and function. Bring the whole book together, show the reader how far she has come, give her a personal plan for the future and a realistic way to handle setbacks, and end with a satisfying, complete close. Book 2 is mentioned briefly as an option for going further, never as the place where the answers are.

Sections

1. **Look what you stopped doing.** A short, punchy recap of the ten trades, one line each: from hiding behind labels to naming the fear; from looping to deciding; from polling the group chat to consulting with intention; and so on to self-approval.
2. **Retake the Tell Inventory.** The reader returns to the checklist from the introduction and compares. The point isn't a perfect score; it's noticing which tells are quieter, and which still need attention.
3. **Your Tell Map.** A one-page personal plan: her top three remaining tells; the early warning signs for each (the situations, people or moods that trigger them); her chosen trade for each; and one person she can be honest with about her progress.
4. **The bad-day plan.** Insecurity will come back, especially when she's tired, stressed or facing something new. That's not failure. A short, four-step routine for those days: name the tell, run the Tell Check, make one small trade, and remind herself of her evidence (her kept promises, her clean noes, her clear questions).
5. **What's showing now.** A closing message in the book's voice: the reader isn't a different person, but she is making different choices, and people can see that too. A brief, non-salesy mention that *Your Power Is Showing* explores what comes next for readers who want to go further into standards, ambition and taking up space.

Takeaway. She has everything she needs to keep going on her own: a method, a set of trades and a plan for the bad days.

Your story (optional). A few closing words from you to the reader: what you hope she does next.

FINAL REALITY CHECK

1. Which tell has changed most since you started this book, and what helped?
2. Which tell is still the loudest, and what's its early warning sign?
3. What do you now do on a hard day that you didn't do before?

Final action: Your 30-Day Check-In. Complete your Tell Map. Then do two things today: make one trade from your map within the next 48 hours, and set a calendar reminder for 30 days from now that says "Tell Map check-in". When it comes up, review your map, update your top three tells and choose your next trade.

SECTION 05

Reality Checks: summary of the weekly actions

Each action targets a specific behaviour and uses a different type of exercise, so the reader is never doing the same thing twice.

Chapter	Action	Type of exercise	Behaviour it targets
Intro	The Tell Inventory	Baseline self-assessment	Recognising personal tells
1	The Label Audit	Noticing log + 10% braver step	Hiding behind identity labels
2	Three Deadlines	Time-bound decision experiment	Indecision and looping
3	The 24-Hour Rule	Delay + tally	Reassurance-seeking
4	The Comparison Trigger Map	Tracking + environment change + decoding	Comparison and envy
5	Count, Then Swap	Counting + language replacement + delayed yes	Over-apologising and the yes reflex
6	Send the Clear Message	Scripted conversation	Tolerating ambiguity
7	One Thing Off the List	Exposure to an avoided activity	Postponing life because of appearance
8	One Clean No	Prediction test	Fear of disapproval
9	The Seven-Day Tiny Promise	Habit tracking	Broken self-promises
10	The Unposted Win	Withholding + self-review	Needing external validation
Concl.	Your 30-Day Check-In	Personal plan + scheduled review	Maintaining change

SECTION 06

Word plan

The counts below refer to the future manuscript (body text only, including each chapter's Reality Check). Front and back matter (title page, copyright, contents, acknowledgements, author bio, any promotional pages) are not counted.

Section	Title	Planned words
Introduction	Yes, It's Showing (And That's Good News)	2,000
Chapter 1	You're Not Shy, You're Scared of Being Judged	3,000
Chapter 2	Overthinking Is Not a Personality	2,800
Chapter 3	Your Group Chat Is Not Your Therapist	2,700
Chapter 4	She's Not Your Competition	2,800
Chapter 5	Stop Asking for Permission to Exist	3,000
Chapter 6	Stop Dating Potential	3,000
Chapter 7	Your Body Is Not the Problem	2,700
Chapter 8	Become Unbothered (It's a Skill, Not a Vibe)	3,000
Chapter 9	Stop Breaking Promises to Yourself	2,800
Chapter 10	Main Character Energy Doesn't Need an Audience	2,600
Conclusion	Now Something Else Is Showing	2,000
Total		**32,400**

By part: Introduction 2,000 · Part One 11,300 · Part Two 8,700 · Part Three 8,400 · Conclusion 2,000.

Notes on the plan

- The total of **32,400 words** sits comfortably above the agreed **minimum of 30,000**. The margin allows normal tightening during editing without falling below the minimum.
- Chapter lengths can vary by about 10% in either direction as the writing develops, but the manuscript total will not drop below 30,000 words.
- Longer chapters (3,000 words) are the ones that carry more tools or scripts: the foundation chapter (1), people-pleasing (5), dating (6) and boundaries (8).
- Each chapter's Reality Check accounts for roughly 200 to 300 words of its total.
- No chapter is padded to reach the target. If a chapter naturally runs short, the extra words go into more worked examples and scripts, which are what readers of this genre use most.
- At around 32,000 words the book remains a quick, "read it in a weekend" title, in line with the short, bingeable format this audience prefers.

SECTION 07

Book 1 and Book 2: the series map

The distinction

	Book 1: *Your Insecurity Is Showing*	Book 2: *Your Power Is Showing*
Core question	"What am I doing out of fear?"	"What do I want, and what am I building?"
Direction	Subtraction: stop the reflexes that keep you small	Addition: build the standards, habits and ambitions that move you forward
Starting point	Reactive habits: apologising, pleasing, comparing, waiting	Deliberate choices: setting standards, taking up space, pursuing goals
Signature tool	The Tell Check (Spot, Story, Cost, Trade)	Its own signature tool, the Pre-Decision (Want, Line, Move, Review), used before a situation rather than during it
The reader at the end	Catches and interrupts insecure behaviour; trusts herself on a small scale	Leads her life with clear standards, confidence and ambition

In short: Book 1 stops insecurity from making her decisions. Book 2 teaches her to make bigger, bolder decisions on purpose.

Theme map

Theme	Covered in Book 1	Developed further in Book 2
Confidence	Acting before you feel ready; confidence as evidence from kept promises (Ch. 9–10)	Confidence as presence: speaking up, visibility, leadership, taking up space
Relationships and dating	Stopping situationships, asking the clear question, leaving cleanly (Ch. 6)	Defining standards in advance, choosing partners intentionally, healthy conflict in committed relationships
Boundaries	Saying no, holding it under pressure, handling guilt (Ch. 5, 8)	Standards: what you expect and choose, not only what you refuse; renegotiating long-standing relationships
Discipline	Small promises to rebuild self-trust (Ch. 9)	Discipline at scale: routines and systems for long-term goals
Work, money and ambition	Only where insecurity blocks her: staying quiet, invisible tasks, not asking (Ch. 5)	Ambition, negotiating pay, money confidence, career moves, building something of her own
Comparison and other women	Interrupting comparison, decoding envy (Ch. 4)	Building a supportive circle; learning from women further ahead; friendship standards
Appearance	Stopping appearance anxiety from making decisions (Ch. 7)	Self-presentation as a confident choice and form of expression, not a requirement for approval

Theme	Covered in Book 1	Developed further in Book 2
Validation	Ending reassurance loops; self-approval (Ch. 3, 10)	Self-respect as a daily standard; making decisions that align with her values

How the two books stay independent

- **Book 1 is complete on its own.** Every problem it raises gets its tools and solutions inside Book 1. The conclusion gives the reader a full personal plan and does not hold anything back for the sequel.
- **Book 2 does not reteach Book 1.** It can briefly refer to the Tell Check for returning readers, but it opens with its own premise and its own tool, so new readers can start there too.
- **Shared voice, different energy.** Both books use the same voice. Book 1 leans more on the reality check; Book 2 leans more on momentum and ambition.
- **Overlapping topics are split by angle, not repeated.** Where both books touch a subject (dating, boundaries, discipline, money), Book 1 handles the *fear-driven habit* and Book 2 handles the *deliberate standard*. The theme map above is the reference for keeping that split clean while both books are being developed in parallel.

The full outline of Book 2 will be developed separately, using this map as the dividing line.

SECTION 08

Points for your review

To finalise the outline before writing begins, it would help to have your thoughts on the following:

1. **Subtitle.** Do you prefer the recommended subtitle, the original draft or one of the alternatives?
2. **Chapter order and titles.** Are you happy with the three-part structure and the revised chapter titles?
3. **Personal stories.** Which of the optional "Your story" prompts would you like to contribute to? Short notes or voice memos are enough; we will shape them into the text with your approval.
4. **How personal the book should be.** Are there topics you'd prefer to keep fully hypothetical (for example dating or body image)?
5. **Your signature touch.** Would you like a hint of Dutch-style directness to be part of your voice, or would you rather keep the voice international and neutral?
6. **How you address the reader.** Should the book use a recurring way of addressing her (a nickname or a phrase that becomes yours), or simply "you"?
7. **Spelling.** This document uses British spelling. Please let us know if you would prefer American spelling for the manuscript.